The Zhou Dynasty

The last king of the Shang Dynasty was Zhou. Around 1,046 BCE, King Wu of the state of Zhou campaigned against King Zhou and defeated his army at the Battle of Muye. Thus, the Zhou Dynasty was founded. The dynasty lasted between 1,046 to 226 BCE with the Western Zhou Period and the Easter Zhou Period dividing it between 1,046 to 771 BCE and 771 to 226 BCE, respectively. It was Zhou's younger brother the Duke of Zhou who cited the Mandate of Heaven because he believed the Shang rulers were no longer acting in accordance with Heaven's blessings. It was an argument which gave the Zhou rulers a legitimate way to declare war on the Shang.

According to him, the Mandate of Heaven was the divine right to rule and govern the people in the best interest of both the people and the gods. When a ruler did not lead accordingly, the Mandate of Heaven would no longer apply to him and the government could be toppled by the gods through the people. Furthermore, the Mandate of Heaven could only apply to one individual who would be the legitimate ruler of the country. This rule was to be handed along the family line from father to son but only if the child himself possessed the right character needed to serve as king. Over the following centuries, this concept was continuously manipulated by those who attempted to seize control of the government.

Chinese culture developed even further during the Zhou Dynasty. The population increased and the borders expanded to new regions. Writing was organized and metal work was advanced to a new level. Some of the greatest philosophers and writers emerged including Confucius, Lao Tzu, Mo Ti and Tao Chien. Sun Tzu is known as the greatest Chinese tactician who lived during this time. All of these individuals lived during what is known as the Hundred Schools of Thought period. The chariot was introduced into the country while the Shang Dynasty was in power but it was during the reign of the Zhou Dynasty that it became something much more suitable for warfare.